



Iron Valley

Derail Valley B99.7 + Unity Mod Manager

Modlist · Installation · Field Manual · Personae

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1 Installation

From a vanilla Derail Valley B99.7 to a modded railway in four steps: game, manager, mods, verify.

1.1 What you need

Item	Value
Base game	Derail Valley — Steam (Early Access; current live build is the B99.7 line, final patch 2025-08-02)
Mod manager	Unity Mod Manager — the community-standard loader (v0.32.5 at the time of writing)
Mods	The curated mods from chapter 2 (foundations, rolling stock, detail mods)
Sources	Steam · Nexus Mods (derailvalley) · GitHub (WhistleWiz) · reshade.me (optional)

Derail Valley is an Early Access game. The last released builds are B99 (November 2024) with the B99.1–B99.7 stability patches through 2025, plus a Unity engine security patch (October 2025) that changed nothing gameplay-wise. The team is now building *B100* — the planned first proper electric locomotive, overhead lines and 100+ new cargo types — with a target around the end of 2027. This guide targets the current live build, and everything here is chosen to work on it.

Good to know

Everything in this guide is downloaded from exactly four trusted hubs: Steam, Nexus Mods, official GitHub repositories, and reshade.me (optional). Never grab Derail Valley mods from random repack or aggregator sites.

1.2 Step 1 — Install and launch the game

1. Install **Derail Valley** from Steam. The game folder is typically `Steam\steamapps\common\Derail Valley`.
2. Launch the game once and play through the tutorial start so the game generates its files and folder structure.
3. Quit and verify the game runs unmodded first. If anything is wrong, fix it before touching mods.

Tip

Your save lives in `DerailValley_Data\SaveGameData\savegame` inside the game folder (the game auto-saves on exit and keeps regular backups there). Copy the whole folder before you start modding — saves are cheap to back up and expensive to lose.

1.3 Step 2 — Install Unity Mod Manager (the mod manager)

Unity Mod Manager (UMM) is the **best mod manager for an avid modder** in the Derail Valley community, and the only one this guide uses:

- It is the ecosystem standard — nearly every current mod is a UMM mod, so one manager covers everything, including the frameworks in chapter 2.
- It gives you a real **mod menu in-game** (`Ctrl+F10`): every mod listed with its version, enable/disable per mod, and per-mod settings from one place.

- It installs mods by **drag-and-drop**: drop a downloaded mod zip onto the Mods tab and it is installed, enabled and updatable — no manual folder surgery.
- It is cross-game (51k+ endorsements, in active development) and can check Nexus for mod updates.
- The game has **no official mod support and no Steam Workshop** — UMM is how the community does it, and the official community modding guide documents it.

The install flow (from the manager's own documentation — follow it exactly):

1. Download the latest release from [the Unity Mod Manager Nexus page](#).
2. Unpack the archive **anywhere you want** — never inside the game folder.
3. Run `UnityModManager.exe`.
4. Go to the **Install** tab and select *Derail Valley* from the game list.
5. If the game folder is not detected automatically, point it at your `Steam\steamapps\common\Derail Valley` folder.
6. Ensure the installation method is set to *DoorstopProxy* (the recommended method for Derail Valley) and click **Install**.
7. The manager is now wired into the game. Leave the manager open for the next step.

1.4 Step 3 — Install the mods

Every mod in chapter 2 follows the same pattern:

1. Download the mod from its page (Nexus Mods or GitHub).
2. Open Unity Mod Manager and go to the **Mods** tab.
3. **Drag and drop** the downloaded .zip directly onto the mod list. UMM installs it, enables it, and shows its status.
4. Install in dependency order: first the frameworks (Language Helper → Custom Car Loader → Custom Licenses → Comms Radio API), then the content that needs them (the locomotive packs, Skin Manager, Loco Ownership, DV Custom Cargo). Each mod card in chapter 2 lists its requirements.

Watch out

Custom Car Loader is version-strict: it *does not support any build before B99.7* (which is exactly the current build), and *all mods built for CCL pre-3.0.0 do not work on the current version*. If a custom locomotive page says “requires CCL”, make sure it is the current CCL release. Also note CCL's own warning: **Number Manager is not compatible with CCL** — that is why it is not in this list.

1.5 Step 4 — Verify and first launch

1. Launch the game through Steam. Unity Mod Manager boots with the game.
2. Open the mod menu with `Ctrl+F10`. All installed mods should show a **green/OK** status.
3. A mod shown in red means it failed to load — usually an outdated version or a missing dependency. Check the mod's Nexus page (Requirements section and Posts/Bugs tabs) for the fix.
4. If a mod misbehaves, disable it from the same menu and test — that is the first troubleshooting move for any problem.

Good to know

Mods can be enabled and disabled individually from the UMM mod menu without touching any files. That makes testing new additions — and isolating the cause of a crash — a two-minute job.

1.6 Updating and removing mods

- **Update a mod:** drag the new zip into UMM (it replaces the old version) or use the manager’s update check.
- **Remove a mod:** disable it in the mod menu, or remove it from UMM’s Mods tab.
- **Update the manager:** download the new release and re-run the installer — your mods and saves are untouched.
- After any change, launch and check the mod list once before playing on.

1.7 Safety rules

- Only Nexus Mods, official GitHub repositories, and reshade.me in this guide.
- Read the **Requirements** section of every mod page — most mods need the current UMM and, for custom rolling stock, the current Custom Car Loader.
- Check the **Last updated** date. Derail Valley is Early Access: every major build has historically broken older mods, and B100 will do it again. A mod updated in the B99.x era is a green flag; a mod untouched since 2023 is a red one.
- Keep one save backup from before modding, and one before each big mod change.

2 The Modlist

What “Iron Valley” actually consists of: Derail Valley B99.7 plus a curated set of foundations, rolling stock and detail mods on Unity Mod Manager — and, just as importantly, what it deliberately leaves out.

2.1 The list at a glance

Property	Value
Base game	Derail Valley B99.7 (current live build; B100 in development, not released)
Mod manager	Unity Mod Manager v0.32.5 (2026-07-29) — Nexus site/mods/21
Curated mods	13 — five foundation frameworks, five locomotives, two detail/immersion mods, one optional graphics tool
Distribution	Nexus Mods (derailvalley) + GitHub (WhistleWiz) + reshade.me (optional) — direct pages only
Playstyle	The vanilla sim, deepened and modernized — more trains, more cargo, more detail; nothing that makes it easier

2.2 Design pillars

- **Deepen & modernize.** The B99 build is a solid, living sim; these mods widen its motive-power pool, deepen its fleet management, and polish its presentation — without moving the goalposts.
- **More trains.** Five community locomotives on Custom Car Loader: two big steam 4-8-4s, a steam shunter, a V/Line diesel and a streamlined diesel with a booster B-unit — every one with real cab work, built to the sim’s standards.
- **More cargo.** Custom Car Loader and DV Custom Cargo together let custom freight cars carry custom cargo types in the live economy — the framework the game’s own 100+ cargo B100 update will later catch up to.

- **Graphics, honestly.** One liveries system (Skin Manager) plus an optional post-processor (ReShade) — no fake “ultra” filters, and no environment overhaul exists that is current and verifiable anyway.
- **No overpowered, no easier.** Nothing that hands out money, licenses, fuel or free rerails; nothing that erases a mechanic the game teaches you by doing. Mods that do exactly that are listed at the end of this chapter with reasons — they are the ones we said no to.

2.3 The core: Unity Mod Manager

Unity Mod Manager is the **best mod manager for an avid modder** in this community, and it is the only one this guide uses. It is covered in detail in chapter 1 — the short version: drag-and-drop installs, an in-game mod menu (`Ctrl+F10`), per-mod settings, per-mod enable/disable, update checks, and a huge multi-game user base that keeps it alive. Everything else in this list runs on top of it.

2.4 Foundations

These five are frameworks: they add little by themselves and enable everything else. Install them first, in this order.

Custom Car Loader (CCL)

Required — the rolling stock framework · v3.1.8

The backbone of the modern Derail Valley mod scene: lets the game load, spawn and simulate community-created locomotives and cars, from the car model in Unity to an assetbundle in your mods folder. Custom locomotives can appear in the world naturally, custom cars can show up in jobs with cargo, and some work trains become purchasable through the regular Work Train menu. It also brings its own custom cargo support (custom cargo types and configurable cargo models for cars) and saves custom-loco state across restarts. Explicitly supports B99.7+ only; all pre-3.0.0 CCL mods are unsupported.

Where: Nexus — [derailvalley/mods/324](#) · [GitHub](#)

Install: Download the zip and drag it into UMM's Mods tab, after Unity Mod Manager and Language Helper.

Risk: None — it is the ecosystem itself. Keep it updated; and remember it is NOT compatible with Number Manager.

Language Helper

Required — localization library

A common library that lets other mods ship translations. It does nothing on its own, but Custom Car Loader, Custom Licenses and Skin Manager all list it as a requirement — install it once and forget it.

Where: Nexus — [derailvalley/mods/823](#) · [GitHub](#)

Install: Drag the zip into UMM's Mods tab, before the mods that require it.

Risk: None.

Custom Licenses

Required — license framework · by WhistleWiz · v1.1.3

A framework for adding custom licenses to the game, so community locomotives can be gated behind their own earnable career licenses instead of being handed out for free. By itself it does nothing; several locomotive packs in this list require it, and the custom licenses appear in the Career Manager like the vanilla ones.

Where: Nexus — [derailvalley/mods/1036](#) · [GitHub](#)

Install: Drag the zip into UMM's Mods tab (needs Language Helper).

Risk: Low — a framework only.

Comms Radio API

Required — comms radio framework · by fauxnik (Niko Fox) · v1.0.3

Lets other mods add their own modes to the in-game Comms Radio device — the same handheld you use for the vanilla car spawner and remote control. Loco Ownership builds on it.

Where: Nexus — [derailvalley/mods/813](#) · [GitHub](#)

Install: Drag the zip into UMM's Mods tab.

Risk: Low. Last updated in the B98 era; still the required dependency for current mods — watch it after B100.

DV Custom Cargo

Cargo framework · by WhistleWiz · MIT

Adds the ability to create and use custom cargo in Derail Valley, fully compatible with Custom Car Loader — so custom freight cars can haul custom commodity types in the live economy, with mass, value and wagon compatibility defined per cargo. Known caveat (from the author): changing the cargo set can clear hazmat-map data in an existing save (visual world markers), so add cargo mods before starting a career, not mid-career.

Where: [GitHub](#) — [WhistleWiz/dv-custom-cargo](#)

Install: Download from GitHub and drag the zip into UMM's Mods tab, after CCL.

Risk: Low. Framework only; read the hazmat-map caveat above before changing the cargo set on an existing save.

2.5 Rolling stock

Five community locomotives, all on Custom Car Loader, all updated in the B99.x era. Each one is a real cab experience — no overpowered stats, no free power: they fit the sim's physics, load ratings and career economy, and several gate themselves behind custom licenses you earn in the Career Manager.

Santa Fe 2900 Class North-erns

Steam 4-8-4 · by GingerBeardLocomotiveWorks · updated 2026-07-27

An ATSF 2900 Class 'Northern' 4-8-4 (Baldwin, 1943–44) in the guise of No. 2901. An oil-burner that runs on diesel fuel in-game, with an eight-axle tender, custom bell animation and extra particle effects, and VR-tested. Big steam for the mainline — think S282 scale, US-style.

Where: [Nexus](#) — [derailvalley/mods/1610](#)

Install: Drag the zip into UMM. Requires CCL + Custom Licenses.

Risk: Low. Check the page for the exact license the custom license adds and what service points it needs.

S484-841 'Sunset'

Steam 4-8-4 · by LittleNiko36 · v1.0.6

A fictional N.E.C.O. 'Sunset' 4-8-4 whose prototype is the SP GS-4 4449 'Daylight' (the page is explicit that this is not 4449 itself). The first Derail Valley steam locomotive that burns diesel instead of heavy oil — no heavy oil exists in-game — with a 190 km/h design speed, load ratings around 4000 t on flat / 2400 t on a 2% grade, a Mars light and a multi-person cab. VR-tested.

Where: [Nexus](#) — [derailvalley/mods/1549](#)

Install: Drag the zip into UMM. Requires CCL + Custom Licenses.

Risk: Low. It is a fast, powerful steam locomotive — respect its braking like you would any big steamer.

VR Class Jk3

Steam 0-8-0 shunter · by CruiserBlade9369 & Lilla · v1.0.1

A fictional 0-8-0 'So80-400' shunter from the 1897–1912 era — roughly an So60-equivalent with better range: about 105 kN tractive effort, a low-profile three-axle tender, 2,500 kg coal and 5,500 L water, a 65 km/h safe maximum, and good visibility both directions for yard work. Fires up, coals up and works the yard like a proper heritage shunter.

Where: [Nexus](#) — [derailvalley/mods/1334](#)

Install: Drag the zip into UMM. Requires CCL + Custom Licenses.

Risk: Low. Steam shunting means water discipline — keep an eye on the tender gauge in the yard.

N Class

Diesel 6-axle · by Sam24815 · v1.1

A V/Line (Australian broad gauge) dual-cab six-axle diesel with power in the DE6 ballpark — a modern mainline hauler with a cab at each end for easy run-arounds. Compatible with passenger jobs, and the page notes optional compatibility with Zeibach's legacy Couplers mod (not used in this list).

Where: Nexus — [derailvalley/mods/1323](#)

Install: Drag the zip into UMM. Requires CCL v3.1.8+.

Risk: Low. Not yet VR-tested by the author at the time of writing — fine for desktop play.

EMC-E Series

Streamlined diesel · by TheDriver01 & Baronvonloco · v1.2.1

A streamlined EMC-E4-inspired E-series diesel with a fully operational Booster B-unit — the classic 'streamlined passenger train' look of the 1930s. About 2,000 hp, a ~190 km/h top end and roughly 1,000 t on a 2% grade, with 16 livery combinations, full VR and HUD support, natural map spawns and Loco Ownership compatibility. Needs the in-game DE6 license to drive — a genuine career gate, not a handout.

Where: Nexus — [derailvalley/mods/1497](#)

Install: Drag the zip into UMM. CCL-based custom car; the page's requirements are sparse, so confirm CCL + Language Helper are current.

Risk: Low. Fast and streamlined — read the cab instruments; this one rewards the careful driver.

2.6 Detail & immersion

Skin Manager

Liveries · by cbethax, Katycat, Zeibach, Cruiser · v4.4.1

The community's livery system: repaint any locomotive or rolling stock (base game or custom) with your own skins through a Comms Radio 'reskin' mode and in-game paint cans, with a packager to bundle your work. Explicitly CCL-compatible. Pure detail — it changes how your fleet looks, never how it runs.

Where: Nexus — [derailvalley/mods/34](#) · [GitHub](#)

Install: Drag the zip into UMM. Requires Language Helper and current UMM; skin packs go into the mod's Skins folder.

Risk: Low. Purely cosmetic.

Loco Ownership

Fleet management · by CruiserBlade9369 · v1.6.1

Lets you buy and own locomotives outright, beyond the museum demonstrators the game hands you. Owned locos stay where you park them (no despawn), can be painted, must be serviced like real machines, and can be sold. Prices come from the in-game locomotive catalog and the relevant license is required — you earn it the hard way, then pay catalogue price. This deepens the career's fleet layer; it does not make anything cheaper or easier.

Where: Nexus — [derailvalley/mods/977](#)

Install: Drag the zip into UMM. Requires Comms Radio API + Language Helper.

Risk: Low. Build-99 compatible; watch for updates when B100 lands.

2.7 Optional: graphics

ReShade

Optional post-processing · [reshade.me](#)

A generic post-processing injector (not a Derail Valley-specific mod) used across PC gaming: ambient light, colour grading, sharpening, and other effects on top of the game's renderer. Included as the *only* honest graphics option that is both current and verifiable — no Derail Valley environment overhaul exists that is maintained for

the B99 line. No community preset was verified for this guide, so the honest advice is to tune it yourself and keep it subtle: night railroading is dark by design.

Where: reshade.me

Install: Run the official installer, pick Derail Valley's executable and the Direct3D 10/11/12 API, then toggle the overlay in-game with the Home key

Risk: Optional — skip it if you value pure vanilla rendering. Disable it before reporting performance or graphical issues, and never pair it with a crashed mod hunt.

Good to know

The one ‘modern comfort’ in this list is ReShade, and it is optional. The line we draw everywhere else: **friction you can feel is the game**. Detail mods and honest performance work deepen it; anything that quietly removes a mechanic, a limit, or a source of tension is out — even when it is popular.

2.8 What we deliberately left out

Every mod below is real, and several are popular — and each one fails a pillar. The reasons are recorded in STATUS.md as well.

- **Number Manager** — dynamic unique numbers on rolling stock, but *Custom Car Loader is explicitly incompatible with it* (CCL's own page says so). Our list is CCL-based; the conflict is not worth the numbers.
- **DV Utilities** — a developer/cheat toolkit: money and license unlocks, unlimited fuel/water/coal, disabling derailment and wheelslip, free rerail, time/weather override. Every one of those makes the game easier, and it is unmaintained since February 2024 (pre-B99).
- **Expanded Station Range** — increases the distance you can leave a station before its jobs despawn. It is a quality-of-life idea, but the mod is unmaintained since July 2023 with no current-build statement; and honestly, the station-range limit is a designed constraint of the career's yard work.
- **Improved Job Overview** — adds track numbers to the job overview before you accept. Last updated August 2023 and officially unmaintained; community reports say it still runs, but the page itself claims nothing.
- **Zeibach's Couplers** — realistic coupler physics (AAR knuckle, SA3, Scharfenberg, link-and-pin). A legend of the older scene, but legacy: the author joined the Altfuture development team and the game's own coupling rework is on the roadmap. No current-build guarantee.
- **DRG Class 01** — a gorgeous 4-6-2, but hidden by its author since September 2023 (“currently not supported”). Unavailable.
- **Class 66, TEM2 / ChME3 and similar** — mentioned in community round-ups, but no currently available release could be verified at build time. Not included rather than guessed at.
- **Booklet Organizer, LightingOverhaul, EasyTex, “Map Enhancer”** — no verifiable current page exists. (Map Enhancer is a **Railroader** mod; LightingOverhaul appears to be an old private BepInEx-era project.) Skin Manager, CCL and the rest of this list cover those pillars with far less risk.
- **Money / cheat / “easy mode” mods generally** — anything that raises income, removes fees, or unlocks licenses is out by the pillar, no matter how polished.

2.9 Download sources

- Nexus Mods — Derail Valley hub: nexusmods.com/derailvalley (all mod cards link their own pages)
- Unity Mod Manager: nexusmods.com/site/mods/21
- GitHub — DV Custom Cargo: github.com/WhistleWiz/dv-custom-cargo
- ReShade (optional): reshade.me

Every mod card above links its own page — check the **Requirements** and **Last updated** fields there before installing; versions move faster than any printed guide, and Derail Valley's next big build (B100) will move them again.

3 How to Play

A field manual for the modded career: what the game actually is, the daily loop, jobs and licenses, the locomotives, driving — and what the mods change once you are in.

3.1 What the game actually is

Derail Valley is a first-person train-driving and career sim set in a fictional mountain valley served by a diesel-era railway. You start as a new hire for the valley's freight railway: a debt of fees to clear, a tutorial DE2 shunter to learn on, and a job booklet that tells you exactly what to move, where, and when.

There is no quest marker that flies you to the action — you physically walk your station, pick a job paper off the table, feed it to the job validator, and go couple up. The difficulty **is** the process: reading the booklet, finding the right siding, driving your train within its limits, and paying the fees your locomotives burn. This guide's mods deepen that process; they do not shorten it.

3.2 The career loop

1. **Walk into a station office.** On the table are job preview papers; next to them the **job validator** and the **Career Manager** machine.
2. **Take a job.** Choose a paper (its heading colour tells you the type), insert it into the validator, and receive the booklet: car numbers, siding numbers, destination, and a time limit.
3. **Do the work.** Couple up, move the consist, finish every step the booklet lists.
4. **Turn it in.** Insert the booklet at any station's validator. Complete = payment (plus a **time bonus** if you beat the deadline). Incomplete = a status report telling you what is left.
5. **Pay your fees** at the Career Manager — fuel, maintenance, and the insurance copay your licenses carry. Keep the fees clear, or the railway stops letting you work.

Tip

The time bonus is real money. Completing jobs under the printed time limit is the difference between climbing the license ladder quickly and being swamped by fueling fees. Be ready to go **before** you accept: locomotive coupled, plan in hand.

3.3 Money and fees

- **Job payments** are your income: freight hauls pay the most, then logistic hauls, then shunting.
- **Fees** accumulate as you run: consumables for engaged locomotives, maintenance, and damage — to your train, the cargo, or the environment. Pay them at the Career Manager; a clean fee record is required to buy licenses.
- **Insurance copay:** most licenses raise the copay you owe after accidents. That is the game's risk economy — big licenses (DE6, Hazmat 3) come with big copays.
- **Service:** paying fees at the Career Manager refuels and resupplies your locomotive; a Manual Service license unlocks the cheaper service points around the map.

3.4 Licenses — the progression spine

There are 22 licenses: three come from the tutorial (**Train Driver**, **Freight Haul**, **DE2**), the rest are bought at any Career Manager with a clean fee record. Licenses unlock locomotives, job types, cargo classes

and longer trains — and most of them raise your copay and tighten the time-bonus deadline, so every step up costs something.

License	Cost	What it unlocks
Shunting	\$1,000	Shunting jobs (yard work)
Train Length 1	\$10,000	Jobs up to 10 cars
Train Length 2	\$20,000	Jobs of any length (needs Length 1)
Logistical Haul	\$20,000	Empty-car hauling jobs (needs Concurrent Orders 1)
Concurrent Orders 1	\$10,000	Two jobs at once
Concurrent Orders 2	\$20,000	Any number of jobs (needs CO1)
Dispatcher	\$10,000	Throw switches from the map
Manual Service	\$20,000	Service points for cheap resupply
Fragile	\$10,000	Fragile cargo jobs (vehicles, animals, fruit)
Hazmat 1/2/3	\$40k / \$130k / \$290k	Flammable, hazardous, most-dangerous cargo (tiered, needs Fragile)
Military 1/2/3	\$100k / \$30k / \$400k	Restricted-zone, military, top-secret cargo (tiered)

Good to know

Locomotive licenses follow the same ladder: DE2 is free from the tutorial, then So60 (\$20k), DM3 (\$30k), DH4 (\$50k), S282 (\$50k), BE2 (\$17k), DM1U (\$18k), and the big one — DE6 at \$200,000, which needs Concurrent Orders 2. The custom locomotives in chapter 2 slot into this system: several gate themselves behind custom licenses you buy at the same Career Manager.

3.5 Job types

- **Freight Hauls** (green heading) — the main earners: take loaded cars from one station's outbound track to another station's inbound track. Highest pay, highest risk; hazmat and military variants pay best and punish derailments hardest.
- **Logistic Hauls** (yellow heading) — moving **empty** cars around, with varied destinations and tracks that may already be occupied. Less pay, excellent practice for route knowledge and light enough for a DE2.
- **Shunting** (red heading) — localized yard work: move cars between tracks, load/unload them, build the consists for the hauls. Least pay, least risk — the game's schoolroom.

Watch out

Jobs only exist while you are inside a station's range: leave the range and unclaimed cars and papers despawn. Claimed consists stay around for about two in-game hours — enough to finish a run, not enough to treat the map as a free parking lot. Plan yard work inside station limits.

3.6 The map and its industries

The valley's railway serves *16 stations*: the cities and towns (City West, Harbor & Town, Food Factory & Town, Goods Factory & Town, Machine Factory & Town), the resource sites (Coal Mine East, Iron Ore Mine East and West, Oil Well North and Central, Farm, Forest Central and South, Sawmill), and the Steel Mill and Military Base. Around them turns an economy with *82 cargo types* as of B99 — coal and iron ore to

the Steel Mill, logs to the Sawmill, food and goods to the towns, cars and machinery out of the Machine Factory, fuel from the Refinery and Harbor, and hazmat or military traffic for the brave.

Tip

Learn the commodity flows and you can predict the job papers: the Steel Mill is the valley's heart (coal + iron ore in, steel products out), the Farm feeds the Food Factory, and everything imported comes through the Harbor. Route knowledge is the difference between a time bonus and a dead heat.

3.7 The locomotives

The current build has *eight locomotives*, all usable, and each has a personality:

Model	Type	Load rating	License
BE2	Battery-electric mi-croshunter	100 t	\$17,000
DE2	Diesel-electric shunter	370 t	Tutorial
DM3	Diesel-mechanical shunter	960 t	\$30,000
So60	Steam 0-6-0 shunter	560 t	\$20,000
DM1U	Diesel-mechanical utility rail vehicle	100 t	\$18,000
DH4	Diesel-hydraulic road switcher	800 t	\$50,000
S282	Steam 2-8-2 mainline	1,390 t	\$50,000
DE6	Diesel-electric mainline	1,320 t	\$200,000

The split that matters: the **modern** locomotives (DE2, DH4, DE6) have self-lapping brakes, remote-control compatibility (except the DE6) and multiple-unit (MU) capability; the **old** ones (DM3, So60, S282) have non-self-lapping brakes and no remote or MU. Steam locomotives add water and coal (or, for some custom ones, diesel) to your pre-trip checklist. The Vehicle Catalog in your inventory shows every spec, load rating and service score — read it.

3.8 Starting the career

The sensible early ladder: learn shunting and the DE2 → buy Shunting, then the DM3 or So60 for stronger yard power → Train Length 1 and Concurrent Orders 1 to stack work → DH4 as the first serious road engine → S282 or the long road to the DE6. Fees stay small early because the licenses you can afford carry small copays.

3.9 Driving

The tutorial booklet hands you the core controls, and everything is rebindable from the in-game settings (`GamePreferences.ini` holds the full key list). The essentials:

- **Throttle and reverser** move the train; **brakes** stop it — an independent brake for the locomotive and a train brake for the consist. Old locomotives brake differently from modern ones: read the cab.
- **Signals, switches and speed limits** are the road rules of the valley. A sharp curve at speed derails cars — or the whole train. Throw switches by hand at the ground, or buy the Dispatcher license to do it from the map.

- **Grades matter.** Every locomotive has a load rating for flat track and a lower one for grades — a consist that rolls on the flat may stall or crawl on the valley's hills. The catalog's load ratings exist to keep you honest.
- **The Comms Radio** is your Swiss-army knife: car spawner, locomotive remote control (a huge help for shunting), and now — with the mods — reskinning and ownership modes.
- **Save anywhere, but deliberately:** the game auto-saves on exit and you can save manually; keep backups of the savegame file before big purchases or mod changes.

3.10 The modded experience

What the Iron Valley mods change once you are playing:

- **Unity Mod Manager** — **Ctrl+F10** in-game: every mod, its version, its settings, enable/disable. This is your dashboard.
- **Custom Car Loader** — the community locomotives spawn in the world naturally and some appear as purchasable work trains; cars with custom cargo can show up in jobs. The five locomotives from chapter 2 are now part of the motive-power pool, each with its own cab, gauges and quirks. Remember: CCL needs the current version, and it does not get along with Number Manager.
- **Custom Licenses** — the custom locomotives' licenses appear in the Career Manager like vanilla ones: earn the fee record, buy the license, drive the machine. No free locomotives.
- **DV Custom Cargo** — the economy can now carry cargo types beyond the vanilla 82, on custom cars. Add cargo packs **before** starting a career — changing the cargo set mid-save can clear hazmat-map markers.
- **Skin Manager** — repaint your fleet via the Comms Radio reskin mode: heritage liveries for the steam fleet, modern schemes for the diesels. Your railway, your colours.
- **Loco Ownership** — buy the locomotives you actually run: they stay where you park them, you service them, and you can sell them on. Build a fleet of demonstrators plus owned machines and treat it like real capital — because it is.
- **ReShade (optional)** — toggle the overlay with **Home** and tune to taste. Night freight is dark by design; resist the temptation to lighten it into daylight.

3.11 Saves, backups & troubleshooting

- **Saving:** auto-save on exit; manual save available in-game.
- **Backups:** the save is `DerailValley_Data\SaveGameData\savegame`; the game keeps automatic backups there too. Copy the folder before mod changes and before licence purchases you would hate to redo.
- **Mod problems:** a mod shown red in the UMM menu is outdated or missing a dependency — check its Nexus page, or disable it and test.
- **Isolation:** when something breaks, disable mods one at a time from **Ctrl+F10**. UMM makes this a two-minute job.
- **The next build:** Derail Valley is Early Access and B100 is coming. Major builds have historically broken mods; when it lands, expect a brief 'wait for updates' period before the list works again — that is normal for this game.

3.12 How to stay out of trouble (a checklist)

- Clear your fees before buying anything; a dirty fee record blocks the license ladder.
- Check the consist against the booklet before you move: wrong cars or wrong sidings cost time bonuses.
- Know your locomotive's load rating and the grades on your route before you accept a heavy haul.
- Slow down for curves and respect the speed signs — a derailment costs more than time.
- Watch water and coal (or diesel) on steam: a dead engine in the middle of the valley is a long walk with a fuel can.

- Back up the save before ambitious purchases — the DE6 is \$200,000 of your time.
- When in doubt, walk the yard. The game rewards the careful railroader.

4 Personas

Who are you on this railway? Five ways to play the same valley — each with a background and the career creation choices that make it yours.

4.1 Before you start: how “creation” works here

Derail Valley has no character creator — no name entry, no appearance sliders. Your identity is what you **decide** in the career itself:

- **The save.** Name your career file and start a new save per persona — each persona gets its own railway, its own debt, its own fleet.
- **The difficulty and the rules.** Every persona below sets its own house rules on top of the game’s difficulty settings: what you may buy, what you must drive, what counts as winning. This is the real “game creation” — the difficulty comes from the rules you keep, not from a menu.
- **The licenses and locomotives.** The career’s license ladder **is** your character build: the order you buy licenses and locomotives defines what kind of railroader you are.
- **The mods.** Chapter 2’s list is one installation; each persona simply leans on the mods that matter to its playstyle.

Good to know

All five personas are playable on the same modlist — the personas differ in goals and self-imposed rules, not in mods. Switch between them on different saves; keep one save backup per persona.

4.2 1. The Yard Apprentice

The Yard Apprentice

Difficulty: medium · Focus: the fundamentals

Background. You are the new hire — literally: the career starts you on a tutorial DE2 with a debt of fees and a booklet. You do not skip anything. Shunting jobs teach you the yard, logistic hauls teach you the routes, and only then do you climb onto the road engines. You play the career the way the game’s own progression intends, and you learn the valley track by track.

Game creation choices

- **Save:** name it after the year you hire on — e.g. apprentice-2026 — one save per persona.
- **House rules:** buy licenses strictly in the cheap-to-expensive ladder (Shunting → Train Length 1 → Concurrent Orders 1 → Logistic Haul); no license you cannot pay for outright with a cleared fee record.
- **Priorities:** master shunting first; use the DE2 until its 370 t rating genuinely runs out; learn one freight corridor before taking a second.
- **Goal:** the DH4 license bought with honest yard and local work — proof you have learned the craft.
- **Mods that shine:** Loco Ownership (buy your first real machine when the DE2 runs out of range), Skin Manager (paint your shunter so it feels like yours), Custom Car Loader (the Jk3 0-8-0 is a natural second shunter).

4.3 2. The Mainline Foreman

The Mainline Foreman

Difficulty: medium · Focus: the diesel era

Background. You are here for the modern railroad: self-lapping brakes, remote control, multiple-unit lashups, and a fleet you own outright. The DE2 is a stepping stone, the DH4 is a tool, and the DE6 is the goal — the \$200,000 machine that says you have arrived. You run the valley the way a real diesel-era foreman would: on time, on spec, with a fleet list in your head.

Game creation choices

- **Save:** mainline — and give the save a company-style note in your head.
- **House rules:** modern locomotives only — no steam purchases until the DE6 is owned; every locomotive you run regularly must eventually be **owned** (Loco Ownership), not borrowed.
- **Priorities:** Freight Hauls and Logistic Hauls; buy Train Length and Concurrent Orders early to run longer, efficient consists; use MU lashups of DE2s, then DH4s, before the DE6.
- **Goal:** an owned DE6 and a small owned fleet (DH4 + DE2) serviced, painted and earning.
- **Mods that shine:** Loco Ownership (the heart of this persona), Skin Manager (fleet liveries), Custom Car Loader (the N Class is a DE6-class dual-cab workhorse; the EMC-E runs like a passenger-era showpiece), DV Custom Cargo (custom freight on your own cars).

4.4 3. The Steam Heritage Engineer

The Steam Heritage Engineer

Difficulty: hard · Focus: the steam fleet

Background. Steam is not nostalgia for you — it is the discipline: fire, water, coal, and a machine that demands attention every kilometre. You learn on the So60 shunter, earn the S282, and then the custom fleet opens the door to the great 4-8-4s — the Santa Fe 2900 Northerns and the S484-841 'Sunset' — plus the little Jk3 for yard work. Every run is a performance, and the valley is your heritage railway.

Game creation choices

- **Save:** steam-heritage — one save per locomotive you consider 'yours'.
- **House rules:** no diesel-hauled freight for your own contracts — the consist moves behind steam or it does not move; water and coal must be managed at the tender, not topped up by magic.
- **Priorities:** So60 license early (\$20k) to learn fire and water in the yard; the S282 (\$50k) for the mainline; then the custom-steam licenses from Custom Licenses — the 2900 and the Sunset are the crown jewels.
- **Goal:** run a complete steam-only roster — So60, S282, Jk3, 2900, Sunset — each owned, painted in heritage liveries, and each with a finished run to its name.
- **Mods that shine:** Custom Car Loader + Custom Licenses (the whole steam expansion), Loco Ownership (park them in your own yard), Skin Manager (heritage paint for every steamer), Comms Radio API (a remote for the yard work that steam cannot do).

Watch out

Steam is the hardest driving in the game: no remote, no MU, non-self-lapping brakes, and a fire that goes out if you ignore it. The Heritage Engineer is a vow, not a tutorial — relax one rule if the first week stops being fun.

4.5 4. The Iron Road Hauler

The Iron Road Hauler

Difficulty: hard · Focus: heavy freight

Background. The valley's economy runs on you: coal and iron ore to the Steel Mill, steel out of it, hazmat and military traffic when the pay is right. You measure success in tonnage moved and fees cleared. Long trains, big

grades, dangerous cargo — the Iron Road Hauler takes the jobs nobody else wants and makes money where others make excuses.

Game creation choices

- **Save:** iron-road — this is the career you grind.
- **House rules:** every job must be a Freight Haul of at least ten cars or a hazmat/military job; no passenger work, no pleasure driving; fees are paid in full before any licence purchase.
- **Priorities:** Train Length 2 and Concurrent Orders 2 fast; Fragile → Hazmat 1/2/3 and Military 1/2/3 as the fee record allows; S282 or DE6 for the heaviest consists.
- **Goal:** a cleared fee record, an owned DE6 (and an owned S282 for the heritage-heavy hauls), and a completed Hazmat 3 run without environmental damage.
- **Mods that shine:** Custom Car Loader (the N Class and EMC-E pull serious tonnage), DV Custom Cargo (new commodities for the hauling), Loco Ownership (your fleet, your risk), Custom Licenses (the big machines are earned, not given).

4.6 5. The Railfan Cruiser

The Railfan Cruiser

Difficulty: easy-going · Focus: the journey

Background. You came for the scenery and the machines: the moon over the mountains, the steam chuffing through the pass, the valley seen from the cab. You take the jobs that appeal, paint your locomotives the way you like them, and treat the career as a ticket to the best seat in the house. The license ladder happens eventually; the photograph at the summit is the real goal.

Game creation choices

- **Save:** railfan — your scenic career.
- **House rules:** no grinding — take a job only when it is interesting or on the way; spend on paint and liveries as happily as on licenses; stop and look whenever the view demands it.
- **Priorities:** passenger and light freight jobs along the prettiest corridors (Harbor, the forests, the mountain grades); collect locomotives to admire rather than to work.
- **Goal:** a small owned fleet in full custom liveries, one memorable run on each — and no regrets.
- **Mods that shine:** Skin Manager (the heart of this persona — every locomotive a canvas), Custom Car Loader (the Sunset, the EMC-E and the 2900 are the stars of the show), Loco Ownership (a personal stable), Comms Radio API (remote control for relaxed solo runs), ReShade (tune the night to taste — but gently).

4.7 How to start a persona run

1. Start a new career and play the tutorial morning to confirm everything works.
2. Quit, back up the fresh savegame, and write your persona's name and house rules on paper — three lines of rules beat a forgotten promise.
3. Install order matters if you are switching personas on one machine: the modlist is shared, only the save differs — keep one backup per persona.
4. Launch, and play the persona's priorities from day one.

Persona	Difficulty	Signature mods
The Yard Apprentice	Medium	Loco Ownership, Skin Manager, Custom Car Loader (Jk3)

The Mainline Foreman	Medium	Loco Ownership, Skin Manager, Custom Car Loader (N Class, EMC-E), DV Custom Cargo
The Steam Heritage Engineer	Hard	Custom Car Loader + Custom Licenses, Loco Ownership, Skin Manager, Comms Radio API
The Iron Road Hauler	Hard	Custom Car Loader, DV Custom Cargo, Loco Ownership, Custom Licenses
The Railfan Cruiser	Easy-going	Skin Manager, Custom Car Loader, Loco Ownership, Comms Radio API, ReShade